

Massachusetts Cultural Resource Information System

Scanned Record Cover Page

Inventory No:	WHI.307
Historic Name:	Gurney, Nathan and Martha Pullman House
Address:	496 Plymouth St
City/Town:	Whitman
Village/Neighborhood:	
Local No:	
Year Constructed:	C 1816
Architectural Style(s):	Federal; Italianate;
Use(s):	Agricultural; Single Family Dwelling House;
Significance:	Agriculture; Architecture;
Area(s):	
Designation(s):	
Building Materials:	Roof: Wood Shingle; Wall: Wood; Wood Clapboard; Foundation: Granite; Stone, Cut;
Demolished	No



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Commonwealth of Massachusetts
Massachusetts Historical Commission
220 Morrissey Boulevard, Boston, Massachusetts 02125
www.sec.state.ma.us/mhc

This file was accessed on: Saturday, June 6, 2026 at 10:44 AM

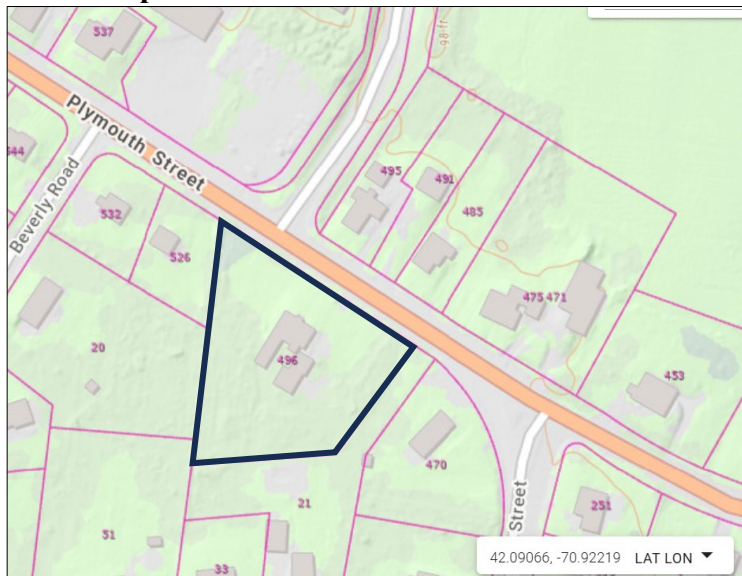
FORM B – BUILDING

MASSACHUSETTS HISTORICAL COMMISSION
MASSACHUSETTS ARCHIVES BUILDING
220 MORRISSEY BOULEVARD
BOSTON, MASSACHUSETTS 02125

Photograph



Locus Map



Recorded by: Lynn Smiledge

Organization: Whitman Historical Commission

Date (month/year): May 2025

Assessor's Number USGS Quad Area(s) Form Number

15-101-5

Whitman

WHI.307
WHI.308

Town/City: Whitman

Place: (neighborhood or village):

Address: 496 Plymouth Street

Historic Name: Nathan Gurney House & Barn

Uses: Present: Dwelling

Original: Dwelling

Date of Construction: Possibly ca. 1816

Source: Marriage date

Style/Form: Federal Cape

Architect/Builder: Unknown

Exterior Material:

Foundation: Granite

Wall/Trim: Wood clapboard / Wood

Roof: Wood shingle

Outbuildings/Secondary Structures:

Barn (late 19th c.)

Garage

Major Alterations (with dates):

South extension to ell (after 1950)

Condition: Excellent

Moved: no ☒ yes ☐ **Date:**

Acreage: 1.15

Setting: Moderately densely settled residential neighborhood on the far east side of Whitman. Former farmland developed in the late 19th through the early 20th centuries for housing to support local industries. Small to moderate-sized dwellings on generous lots with house forms ranging from Capes to Colonial Revival.

RECEIVED

AUG 11 2025

MASS. HIST. COMM.

INVENTORY FORM B CONTINUATION SHEET

WHITMAN

496 PLYMOUTH STREET

MASSACHUSETTS HISTORICAL COMMISSION

220 MORRISSEY BOULEVARD, BOSTON, MASSACHUSETTS 02125

Area(s)

Form No.

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WHI.308

☐ Recommended for listing in the National Register of Historic Places.

If checked, you must attach a completed National Register Criteria Statement form.

Use as much space as necessary to complete the following entries, allowing text to flow onto additional continuation sheets.

ARCHITECTURAL DESCRIPTION:

Describe architectural features. Evaluate the characteristics of this building in terms of other buildings within the community.

The dwelling at **496 Plymouth Street** occupies a 1.15-acre polygonal lot on the south side of the street and faces north. The house is deeply set back from the street and fronts an expansive lawn. Large foundation plantings partially obscure the façade. The front lawn and side yards are sparsely dotted with shrubs and mature trees. A row of trees borders the eastern property line and the balance of the parcel is heavily vegetated. A paved driveway enters and exits the property from Plymouth Street, circling past the east porch of the main block, a barn sited off the southeast corner of the dwelling, and a small garage located west of the barn.

This full Cape form house was constructed around 1816. It comprises a one-and-one-half-story, side-gabled, five-bay-by-three-bay main block with a long, narrow ell at the west end of the south elevation and a small shed-roofed projection at the north end. A one-story, hip-roofed, partially enclosed porch spans the east elevation. The house has a granite foundation. It is clad in wood shingles and has a wood shingle roof. A substantial brick chimney rises from the center of the roof ridge.

Trim at the house includes narrow corner and frieze boards and short eave returns. The centered entry at the main block contains a six-panel wood door with a wide, flat surround, partial-height sidelights, and a deep architrave. The door is sheltered by a flat-roofed hood with elaborate, carved scroll brackets with pendants. The door surround appears to conceal early sidelights and perhaps a transom. The door fronts a granite stoop which lands at the lawn. The windows at the main block are uniform in size and the majority contain two-over-two sash framed by narrow flat surrounds with lipped lintels. The windows at the façade (north elevation) touch the frieze board and have blinds. The paired second-story windows at the east elevation contain earlier six-over-six sash and are flanked by eave closet windows. A contemporary fixed, multi-light window occupies the center bay of the west elevation.

The porch spanning the east elevation of the main block has a shallow hipped roof and is open at the northernmost two bays. The open portion has a molded frieze, spindle railing, and slender Doric columns. An entry at the north wall of the enclosed portion of the porch (comprising the southernmost two bays) opens to the porch deck, which descends to the driveway via a single stone step. The one-story ell is set back from the west elevation of the main block. It comprises a short, early component at the south wall of the main block, and a later (post-1950) southern extension.

The front-gabled barn (WHI.309), which is shown on the 1903 map, is sited close to the southwest corner of the dwelling. It is one-and-one-half stories tall with a gabled rear addition. The barn is clad in wood clapboards, trimmed with narrow corner and frieze boards and a water table, and has a wood shingle roof. A two-leaf batten barn door at the west corner of the façade is surmounted by a hay door. (For more information about the barn see page 2.)

The dwelling at 496 Plymouth Street was built in the full Cape form. The Cape Cod house form, a one-story, side-gabled house with a central chimney and steeply-pitched roof, emerged in southeastern New England ca. 1700 and saw continued use through the mid-19th century. The full Cape design was one of the later iterations of the house type. Defining characteristics of the Cape style illustrated in this house include the full Cape configuration (five bays with center entry), side-gabled roof, and center chimney. The door surround with sidelights and the eave closet windows are consistent with the Federal (1780-1820) stylistic period. The door hood with its scroll brackets is a later Italianate addition (1850-1880) and the two-over-two window sash configuration is characteristic of late 19th and early 20th century styles.

INVENTORY FORM B CONTINUATION SHEET

WHITMAN

496 PLYMOUTH STREET

MASSACHUSETTS HISTORICAL COMMISSION

220 MORRISSEY BOULEVARD, BOSTON, MASSACHUSETTS 02125

Area(s)

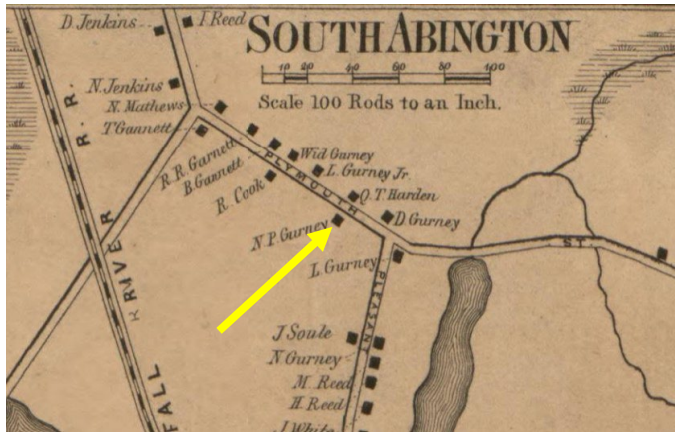
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WHI.308

HISTORICAL NARRATIVE

Discuss the history of the building. Explain its associations with local (or state) history. Include uses of the building, and the role(s) the owners/occupants played within the community.

The town of Whitman in southeastern Massachusetts, originally settled in the northern part of Bridgewater, became part of the town of Abington in 1712. In 1875 the area separated from Abington and was designated South Abington. In 1886 the citizens changed the name of the town to Whitman after one of its prominent families. Agriculture was the basis of the town's economy during its formative years, but only dairy farming persisted into the 20th century. By the early 19th century Whitman's economy was primarily driven by the tack making and lumbering industries. The lumber was used for shipbuilding and wooden box manufacturing. The mid-19th century saw the establishment of boot and shoe factories and ancillary businesses, which soon dominated the local economy. Other products manufactured in Whitman included coffins, packing boxes, and nails. The town is remembered for its early mustering of troops to serve in the Union Army. Whitman's company was the first in the state to report fully equipped for duty at the outset of the Civil War. The town is also associated with the creation of the Toll House cookie in the 1930s by Ruth Wakefield, the owner of the Toll House Restaurant.



1857 map.

Plymouth Street (MA Route 58) is located in the northeast corner of Whitman and runs roughly north to south between the Abington and Hanson town lines. The historic maps of the town show relatively little change between 1857 and 1903 in this more rural part of Whitman. The 1857 map shows a cluster of dwellings along the northeast side of the road between Pleasant and Essex Streets. These properties were among the farmsteads which provided the livelihood of many of the early residents of the town.

This house appears on the 1857 with N.P. [Nathan Pulling] Gurney shown as the owner; a number of dwellings owned by members of the Gurney family are seen in its vicinity. The 1879 map does not include this part of Whitman. The dwelling is labeled C.W. [C. Waldo] Dyer on the 1903 map. The earliest recorded conveyance found in a clear chain of ownership for the property was its sale in 1899 by Clarissa Gurney, the widow of Nathan P. Gurney, to Julia C.

Johnson, the wife of Cyril Johnson. The builder of this full Cape form house was most likely Nathan Gurney, the father of Nathan P. Gurney, who likely constructed it around the time of his first marriage to Martha Pullman in 1816.

Farmer and shoemaker Nathan Pulling Gurney (1818-1888) was devised the property by his parents, Nathan Gurney (1769-1850) and Martha Pullman Gurney (1780-1818). He was married twice, first to Carolina W. Alger (1817-1865) and after her death to Clarissa (Clara) E. Briggs (1833-1807). The widowed Clarissa Gurney sold the farm in 1899 to Julia C. Johnson, who in 1903 with her husband Cyril Johnson sold it their daughter Emma A. Dyer (1851-1936), the wife of C. Waldo Dyer. Cyrus Waldo Dyer (1847-1922) was born in Abington, the son of Cyrus A. Dyer and Jane P. Stetson. His occupation was noted in the 1900 census as auctioneer and from 1910 to 1930 as real estate agent. Emma Dyer owned the property until 1932, when it was acquired by Gervis and Nellie Pond, who would own it for the next 56 years. Gervis A. Pond (1900-1991) was an independent office equipment repairman who started his career with the Multigraph Company of Cleveland, Ohio, maker of Multigraph printing machines.

The Barn (WHI.308)

The Sanborn fire insurance maps shown below help document the progression of the barn and outbuildings on the property. The 1911 map shows the barn with a small shed to the rear (south). By 1919, the shed has been converted to a garage, marking the start of the automobile age. The 1939 map shows that the barn itself has been converted to a two-story structure for automobile storage.

INVENTORY FORM B CONTINUATION SHEET

WHITMAN

496 PLYMOUTH STREET

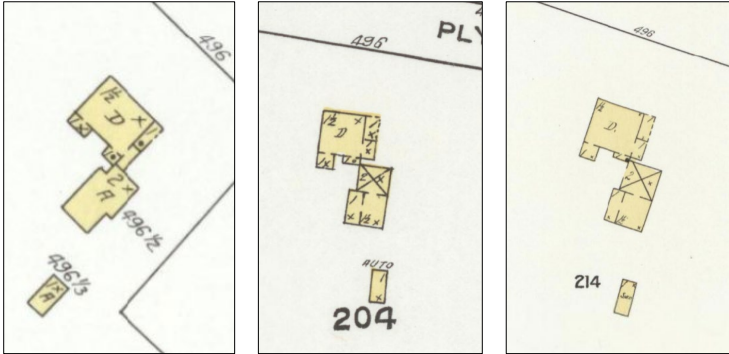
MASSACHUSETTS HISTORICAL COMMISSION

220 MORRISSEY BOULEVARD, BOSTON, MASSACHUSETTS 02125

Area(s)

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Left to right: 1911, 1919, and 1939 Sanborn maps.

Title Research

Date	Book-Page (Certificate)	Grantor	Grantee
10-10-2024	59340-338	Charles A. Denault, Trustee	Elliot w. Denault III
11-07-1988	8816-71	Conservator of Gervis A. Pond	Charles A. Denault, Trustee
05-19-1932	1628-480	Emma A. Dyer	Gervis A. & Nellie I. Pond
10-03-1903	876-275	Cyril & Jula C. Johnson	Emma A. Dyer & C. Waldo Dyer
08-26-1899	784-259	Margaret J. Spaulding	Julia C. Johnson
08-26-1899	784-258	Clarissa B. Gurney	Margaret J. Spaulding
		Estate of Nathan V. Gurney	Clarissa B. Gurney

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Plymouth County Registry of Deeds

INVENTORY FORM B CONTINUATION SHEET

WHITMAN

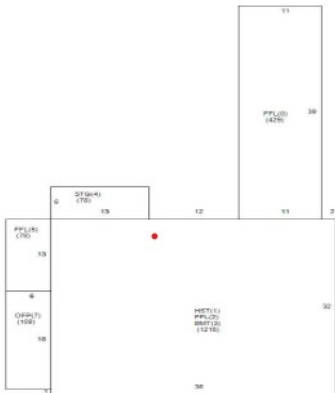
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Assessor's card plan



Façade (north elevation).



North (façade) and west elevations.

INVENTORY FORM B CONTINUATION SHEET

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Photograph labeled 496 Plymouth St., 1938. Image courtesy of Dyer Memorial Library & Archives, Special Collections.